

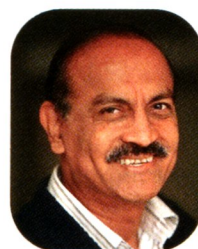
Winning the Peace

For Sri Lankan President Mahinda Rajapakse, winning the war against the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) had seemed the most difficult part. After all, when he took over as president in 2005, the Tigers occupied one-third of the island's territory, running a parallel civil administration in the areas they controlled. The majority Sinhala community was hopelessly divided over the issue and the Sri Lankan armed forces were a demoralised lot. Rajapakse won a narrow victory by riding a rickety Sinhala chauvinistic chariot and promising to defeat the Tigers. For the first year or so he issued ultimatums to the LTTE and went through the motions of finding a political solution to the Tamil issue, even as he considerably refurbished the Sri Lankan armed forces. He then launched a systematic military campaign that instead of focusing only on gaining control of the highways moved into the dense Wanni jungles to clear the LTTE from its hideouts. The Sri Lankan Army pulled off a spectacular success by first taking the Eastern Province and more recently driving the LTTE out of its bastions in the north and possibly forcing Tiger chief V. Prabhakaran to flee his lair. With a million Tamil civilians caught in the crossfire, a serious humanitarian crisis resulted, forcing both India and the international community to call for a ceasefire and immediate assistance to the war displaced.

Rajapakse must realise that winning peace will be even more difficult than defeating the LTTE. For most part of the war the international community, including India, had allowed Rajapakse a free hand while he decimated the Tigers. But now world sympathy has shifted significantly to the plight of the Tamils and the ethnic struggle they have been waging for 50 years. When the war was still on, Rajapakse should have put out an acceptable devolution package that would have met most of the legitimate aspirations of the Tamil minority. He missed that chance.

SAURABH SINGH

Now the Sinhala majority, euphoric over the military success, may not want to yield too much to Tamil demands. That would be a mistake for the resentment among Tamils may see them back a militant struggle again. Even though the Sri Lankan army has all but wiped out the LTTE's ability to wage conventional military battle, the remaining Tigers could resort to guerrilla warfare and devastating suicide attacks. Rajapakse may call a snap poll to cash in on his popularity and allow his party to break free from the constraints of coalition politics by obtaining a substantial majority in Parliament. While that is a legitimate exercise, Rajapakse should shun triumphalism and opt for a statesmanlike approach by coming out soon with a grand gesture for the Tamils. Only then would there be hope for lasting peace in Sri Lanka.



RAJAPAKSE SHOULD SHUN TRIUMPHALISM AND COME OUT SOON WITH A GRAND GESTURE FOR THE TAMILS.



NAMED: Steel tycoon **L.N. Mittal** as the richest Indian billionaire despite his wealth tumbling from £27.7 billion to £10.8 billion

SHEKHAR GHOSH



in a list compiled by London's *Sunday Times*.

NOMINATED: Poet and critic **Arvind Krishna Mehrotra** for the post of the University of Oxford's Professor of Poetry, a position held in the past by poets like Matthew Arnold, W.H. Auden and Seamus Heaney.

DIED: **Ziaur Rahman**, 67, one of the greatest tiger trappers in the post-Jim Corbett era. He had 65 trappings and 40 tiger kills to his credit.

APPOINTED: Vice-Admiral **Sanjeev Bhasin** as Flag Officer Commanding-in-chief, Western Naval Command. He was formerly commandant, National Defence College. He replaces Vice-Admiral Jagjit Singh Bedi.

